

GNU Emacs: Shells, Spell-Checkers, Abbreviations and Printing

Delving deeper into Emacs, this article takes a look at shells, spell-checkers, abbreviations and printing with Emacs.

In this article in the GNU Emacs series, we shall learn how to execute shell commands, run shells, use spell-checkers and abbreviations, and print from GNU Emacs.

Shell mode commands

You can run a shell command from GNU Emacs using the *M-!* shortcut. For example, typing *M-!* will prompt you with the message 'Shell command:' in the minibuffer. If you then type 'date', it will produce the output 'Tue Dec 8 21:19:24 IST 2015' in the minibuffer. But, if you want the output to be inserted in the current buffer you can use the *C-u M-!* command sequence.

Consider the following poem that I wrote:

*"Water, water everywhere
Little power and aid to spare
Really tough for us to bear
We will face it with Chennaites' flair."*

*Lakes and rivers overflowing everywhere
No road, rail or plane to go anywhere
People really are in great despair
But we will ride it with Chennaites' flair.*

*More storms are forecast to be aware
Nothing like this in 100 years to compare
Stay indoors and please do take care
And we will take it with Chennaites' flair."*

Suppose I want to know the number of words used, I can mark the poem as a region in the GNU Emacs buffer, and execute a shell command for the region using the *M-|* shortcut. It then prompts with the string 'Shell command on region', and when I type in 'wc -w', it returns '90'.

Shells

There are three shells available in GNU Emacs — shell, ansi-term and eshell. Using *M-x shell* will invoke a shell for you. This starts a new buffer with the name **shell** in it. You can use all the GNU Emacs buffer commands in this window. For example, *C-p* will move the cursor up, and *C-n* will move the cursor down. In order to interrupt a current job in the shell buffer, you can use *C-c C-c*. If you want to suspend the

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- # emacs shell --help
Usage: emacs shell (cmd) [cmd options]

Available Commands:
  about      About the emacs shell plugin
  cmd        Run shell command(s) passed by parameter
- #
- # emacs shell cmd --help
Usage: emacs shell cmd [cmd options]

Description:
  cmd        Run shell command(s) passed by parameter

Cmd options:
  -i|--interactive <file> ...
    Shell command(s) to execute (required)
  -o|--output <file>
    Specifies a log file to redirect the command's output
  -e|--stderr <file>
    Append to existing log file(s) if also set
  -l|--logfile <file>
    and/or --stderr is not also set
  -f|--logfile <file>
    Provides a log file to redirect the command's
    standard and error output to (can also --stderr)
  -d|--working-dir <dir>
    Specifies a working directory for the shell command(s)
```